

Apply to be a Science Corps Fellow - Entry #3396

Name
Prasita Dutta
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Gender
Female
Residence: City (State), Country
Oxford
Nationality
Indian
When did you or do you expect to complete your PhD?
June 2026
Please tell us briefly about your university education (institution, city, country, year)
Degree: PhD in Inorganic Chemistry Institution: University of Oxford City, Country: Oxford, United Kingdom Year of study: 4th
Note: While I would ideally be inclined to apply for the June 2026 fellowship, in case my PhD defense is not scheduled by that time, I might have to travel back to the UK for a few days during the fellowship to accommodate that.
Why would you like to be a Science Corps Fellow?
Being a teacher is easy; being a good teacher is rare, and I am a direct product of one. I would not be where I am today, in the final year of my doctorate in Chemistry at the University of Oxford, without a chemistry tutor who believed in me at a time when I was still learning to believe in myself. That single influence changed not only my academic trajectory, but also how I view education and teaching. Throughout my PhD, despite the intensity and demands of the program, I have always felt a strong pull toward teaching and mentoring. I have worked with students who are confidently pursuing careers in STEM, as well as those who simply needed reassurance that it was okay to be curious, uncertain, or different. I see teaching not as the transfer of knowledge alone, but as the act of creating a safe space where students feel seen, capable, and encouraged to explore paths they may not have thought possible. I have intentionally sought out opportunities both within Oxford and beyond to share what I have learned,

academically and personally, with students from diverse backgrounds. Every interaction has reinforced my belief that sometimes the most meaningful impact comes not from delivering perfect explanations, but from offering patience and an approachable environment for students to speak their minds out freely.

When I came across Science Corps, it immediately felt like a natural extension of everything I value about education. While I plan to pursue a career focused on the industrial application of chemical technologies I have been working on during my PhD, I have always envisioned dedicating a meaningful period of time after my PhD to teaching. Science Corps offers the chance to do that and be present where support is most needed and to contribute in a way that goes beyond traditional academic settings.

I hope to be the kind of teacher, mentor, or even just a trusted friend that my own tutor once was to me. Teaching, to me, remains the most rewarding profession, not because of what it gives back, but because of what it allows one to give. Becoming a Science Corps Fellow would allow me to dedicate myself fully to that purpose, and I would consider it a genuine privilege to do so.

In addition to your studies, please describe any prior experience that may help you as a Science Corps Fellow.

Alongside my PhD at the University of Oxford, I have been actively engaged in teaching, mentoring, and science outreach initiatives that align strongly with the mission of the Science Corps Fellowship- expanding access to high-quality STEM education and fostering inclusive learning environments.

My teaching experience is rooted in chemistry education across diverse academic and cultural contexts. I am involved in undergraduate laboratory demonstration at Oxford, where I oversee chemistry laboratory experiments, support student learning, and promote safe and responsible laboratory practices. These roles have strengthened my ability to communicate complex scientific concepts clearly to a diverse set of audience.

Beyond the university setting, I work with Oxford Global, an independent Oxford-based social enterprise founded by university alumni. Through this role, I attended the Asian Summit of Young Leaders in Shanghai in both 2023 and 2024, where I taught chemistry to aspiring Chinese students as part of intensive summer schools. I also conducted mock STEM interviews for prospective undergraduate applicants to top UK universities, helping students develop both subject confidence and academic communication skills.

I have further contributed to widening participation initiatives through STEM@OxBridge, in collaboration with the London-based organisation Generating Genius, which supports students from Black African and Caribbean backgrounds and those from low socio-economic communities. As part of this program, I delivered chemistry lectures and led a multidisciplinary poster-making competition on the theme of energy, encouraging students to explore scientific concepts creatively across physics, chemistry, and environmental science.

Additionally, through the Xcelerate Group, an education-access initiative founded by Cambridge alumni, I have mentored Japanese high school students interested in pursuing STEM careers, with a particular focus on navigating the UK curriculum and university pathways.

Collectively, these experiences have equipped me with strong pedagogical skills as well as a cross-cultural teaching experience in STEM- qualities I am eager to bring to the Science Corps Fellowship.

Where do you imagine yourself professionally in the future? Check all that apply.

Scientist in academia

Doing science in industry

Please expand on your selection above and describe where you imagine yourself professionally in the near (~2 year) and long-term (~10 year) future.

In the near term, following the completion of my PhD, I hope to take a short break and immerse myself in teaching and mentoring before transitioning into an industrial research role in chemistry. My doctoral work has focused on principles underlying greener carbon capture and utilisation/storage (CCUS) technologies, and I am motivated to continue developing these ideas in industry, where scientific innovation must align with scalability, timelines, and real-world impact.

Over the next few years, I envision myself working as a researcher in the industrial sector, gaining hands-on experience in translating laboratory-scale chemistry into deployable technologies. In the long term, I aim to move toward founding or co-founding a start-up focused on novel CCUS technologies inspired by the research principles I have explored during my PhD.

I am often asked why, if my goal is to build a start-up, I would choose to spend several years working in industry first. My answer is rooted in the same philosophy that shapes my approach to teaching: one truly understands the value of good mentorship only after being on the receiving end. Similarly, to build impactful technologies, one must first understand the environment in which they will be deployed. Industrial experience provides critical insight into consumer expectations, market constraints, and decision-making processes- perspectives that are often limited in purely academic settings, where focus tends to remain on scientific plausibility alone.

I believe this exposure will allow me to design technologies that are not only scientifically robust but also aligned with real-world demands and adoption timelines. The lessons learned in industry will be essential in shaping solutions that can move beyond proof-of-concept toward meaningful climate impact.

While I do not envision teaching as my primary profession in the long term, education and mentorship will remain a constant part of my career. I am deeply committed to continued involvement in outreach and teaching in some capacity, and I view affiliations with organisations such as Oxford Global and Science Corps as lifelong commitments. These platforms will allow me to keep contributing to education and community engagement alongside my work in research and innovation.

Please upload your CV (.pdf)

 [Prasita-Dutta-Resume1.pdf](#)

How did you find out about Science Corps?

An email list in your institution

[Science Corps](#)